Mom Needs Care and the Application Is on Your List: What to Do With the Paperwork First

Four first moves with the paperwork, in order, and what to leave for a professional.

Between the calls from the rehab and the decisions about where Mom goes next, someone asked whether you've started the Medicaid application. On the table there's a folder of statements and a stack of mail, and no single page that shows what you have.

Start here. Four things, in this order.

1 Put all of it in one place, with the agency's mail on top

Bring the folder of statements, the stack of mail and anything the rehab or the facility has handed you to one table, and choose one box or binder to hold it. As you go, pull out anything from the Medicaid agency and put it on top. Tell one other person in the family where the box lives. [1]

WHY THIS COMES FIRST Everything else you do with the paperwork refers back to this box, and the agency's letters are the papers you'll want to be able to put your hand on.

2 Sort what you have, and write “not found yet” where there's nothing

Lay the papers out under plain headings: identity and residency, income, bank accounts, investments and retirement, insurance, real estate, trusts and annuities, care and facility information. On one sheet, list what you have under each heading and the dates each statement covers. Where a heading is empty, write “not found yet.” Applying means a form plus documents that back it up, and what a state asks for depends on the state, so the aim today is a list, not a finished set. [2] [3]

WHY THIS COMES FIRST Sorting comes before searching. A blank on the list shows you where to look next, and which blanks matter is for a professional to say.

3 Start one log of what has been sent and asked for

On a second sheet, make four columns: the date, what happened, what was sent or asked for, and who you spoke with. Enter what you already know: an application or a document someone has sent, a letter that asked for something, a call from the agency or the business office. Where a letter states a date for replying, copy it exactly as printed. If nothing has been sent yet, leave the log ready.

WHY THIS COMES FIRST Letters and calls arrive in the middle of care decisions. One dated page keeps a request from getting lost in the mail pile.

4 Write down the questions the pile can't answer

Three belong at the top: which Medicaid program and application fit Mom, where and how it is submitted, and when it should go in. Applications go through the Medicaid agency in Mom's state, and the federal long-term care site says the best time to apply depends on a person's medical situation, marital status and the complexity of their finances. Add your own questions underneath, and note beside each one who you think can answer it. [4] [2]

WHY THIS COMES FIRST These questions shape the rest of the step, and none of them can be answered from a folder. They go to your Medicaid planner.

What to leave for a professional

- When Mom's application should go in. That is worked out with your Medicaid planner.

- Which records her state asks for, and how far back they need to go.
- What a letter from the Medicaid agency means, and how to answer it.
- How any question on the application form should be answered.
- Deposits, withdrawals or transfers that nobody can explain. List them with their dates and leave them as they are; your Medicaid planner goes through them with you before anything is submitted.
- Any decision about Mom's money, her home or her accounts.

One thing not to guess at

A letter from the Medicaid agency that asks for something. Don't work out by yourself what it means or when a reply is due. Copy the date on the letter, what it asks for and any reply date it states onto your log, in the letter's own words. Then take it to your Medicaid planner or call the office that sent it, and write down who you spoke with.

What this guide doesn't do

It doesn't say when Mom should apply, what any letter means or whether she may qualify for anything, and it isn't legal, financial or tax advice. It puts the first round of paperwork in order.

Ready for the next step?

You've got the paperwork in one place, a list of what you have and haven't found, a log, and your questions set aside for a professional. The planning interview takes it from there: it asks about your family's situation and gives you a free planning report you can bring to any conversation about paying for care.

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WHERE THIS COMES FROM

Keeping important papers in one place and telling someone where they are follows the National Institute on Aging. That applying takes a form and supporting documents, and that the best time to apply depends on the person's situation, come from the federal long-term care site; that what is required depends on the state is USA.gov's; that applications go through the state Medicaid agency is Medicaid.gov's. The headings, the log and the order are ours.

1. National Institute on Aging, Getting Your Affairs in Order Checklist: Documents to Prepare for the Future
2. Administration for Community Living (LongTermCare.gov), Applying for Medicaid
3. USA.gov, How to apply for Medicaid and CHIP
4. Centers for Medicare & Medicaid Services (Medicaid.gov), Where Can People Get Help With Medicaid & CHIP?